

German-born physicist Albert Einstein developed the general and special theories of relativity, which utterly transformed the concepts of space, time, and gravity. His ideas were the most profoundly influential in 20th-century physics and paved the way for groundbreaking technologies, such as nuclear energy and solar power.

MILESTONES

PUBLISHES PAPERS

Writes four scientific papers in 1905 that bring attention from academics around the world.

SEMINAL WORK

While a professor at the University of Berlin, publishes “General Theory of Relativity” in 1915.

GLOBAL RECOGNITION

Awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics for services to theoretical physics in 1921.

LEAVES GERMANY

Emigrates to the US in 1933 due to the rise of Nazism and oppression of Jews in Germany.

ADVOCATES PEACE

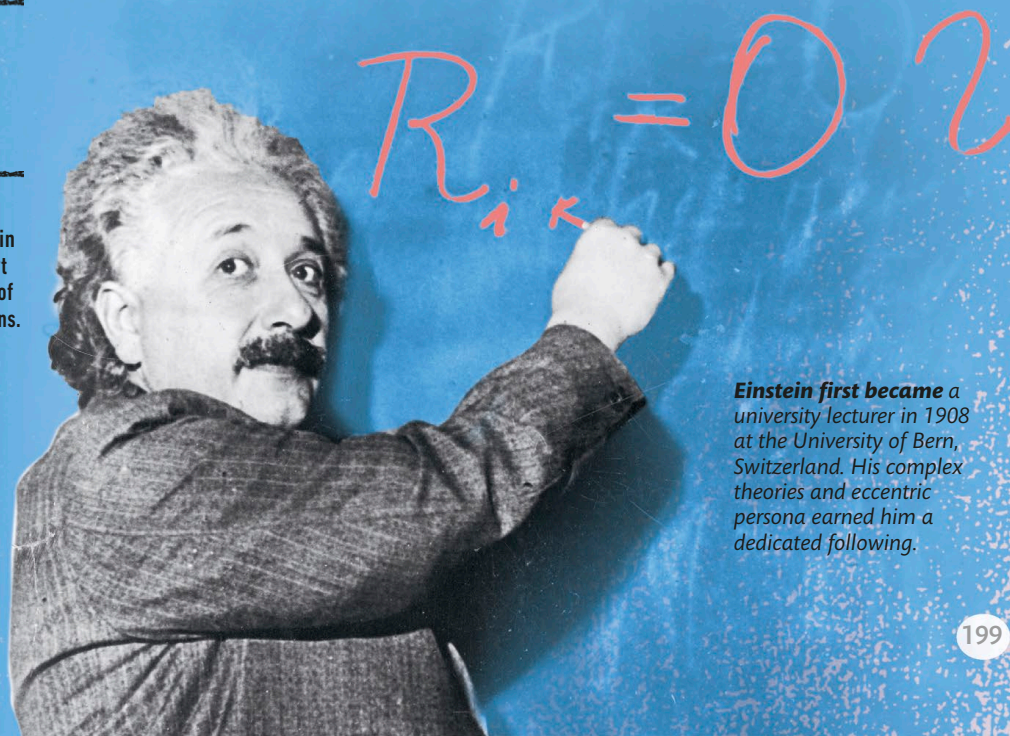
Signs the Russell-Einstein Manifesto in 1955 to alert the public to the dangers of developing nuclear weapons.

Born to Jewish parents in Ulm in southern Germany, Albert Einstein had a natural talent for mathematics and a love of learning. He completed his schooling in Switzerland after spells in Munich and then Italy, where the family moved due to the failure of his father’s electrical engineering business. After qualifying as a teacher, he was unable to secure a teaching post, and instead began work as a clerk at the Swiss patent office in 1902.

Einstein’s relatively lowly position as a third-class technical expert gave him the necessary time to work on his own research interests. By considering the possible solutions to untestable problems (intuitive “thought experiments”), over the next few years, he made a series of breakthroughs that would transform the fundamental laws of physics.

Landmark findings

In 1905, Einstein submitted his doctoral thesis at the University of Zurich and had four landmark papers published in the journal *Annalen der Physik*. Two of these explained phenomena that had long puzzled scientists: the “photoelectric effect” and “Brownian motion.” In elucidating



Einstein first became a university lecturer in 1908 at the University of Bern, Switzerland. His complex theories and eccentric persona earned him a dedicated following.